

INTRODUCTION

The old is dying and the new cannot be born; in this interregnum a great variety of morbid symptoms appear.

—Antonio Gramsci¹

In the years since 2016, it has seemed at times as if the world was coming apart. From the election of Donald Trump to the presidency of the United States, to the UK's vote to leave the European Union, and from the global COVID-19 pandemic to the early signs of catastrophic climate collapse, the world seemed to be running the script of a particularly unsubtle dystopian fiction. Where previously order, of a sort, had reigned, now everywhere disorder was spreading. The 'rules' that were deemed to govern politics and economics were rapidly discarded. What once seemed impossible rapidly became inevitable. All the signs have become present that we are living through an epochal crisis. This is the global crisis of neoliberalism.

Neoliberalism, which is the political system that has ruled almost the entirety of the planet since the 1990s, is everywhere in decline, if not ruination. Meanwhile, its successors scrabble in the debris left behind for new forms of power. As this global political crisis collides with a planetary health crisis, against the backdrop of an intensifying environmental crisis, the systems of order that regulate our political world have been plunged into disarray. We are in a moment of grand realignment, where different cycles of world history have clicked together to produce a rare instant where more or less anything could be possible.

We are writing this book as something of a guide as to what we, the political left, should do in these uncertain times. To understand this era requires thinking much more broadly than we are accustomed to, to go beyond our commonplace obsessions and reflexes. We have to think about how power actually works, not just in specific circumstances, such as during an election or the emergence of a social movement, but in general.² To do so we need to be thinking about politics through the idea of *hegemony*.

Power and Hegemony

Today, the term ‘hegemony’ is used fairly commonly, but in quite different ways.³ Perhaps most often it is used to describe the domination or influence of one nation-state over another (e.g., ‘American geopolitical hegemony’). This is indeed the root meaning of the term, as it emerges from ancient Greek. Sometimes too we might hear it being used to describe an influential social norm (e.g., ‘hegemonic masculinity’). But perhaps the most significant development of the idea of hegemony, and the one we will be using for the most part in this book, was developed by the Italian communist writer, politician, and journalist Antonio Gramsci.

Gramsci was one of the founders of the Italian Communist Party and spent much of the end of his life as a political prisoner under the despotic rule of Benito Mussolini’s fascists. His writings roamed over many topics, such as political history, philosophy, and culture. Underpinning them all was an emerging idea about how power worked, which he termed ‘hegemony’. In a sense this was all about political leadership, of a collective and emergent kind. How was it, Gramsci asked, that relatively small groups come to rule large, complex societies as a whole? How was it, for example, that a relatively modest social faction like the fascists had come to control such a large and diverse society as Italy in the 1920s? This kind of question remains at the heart of our work today. Though hegemony is often used to try to understand how settled situations of power work, it is also invaluable to thinking through moments where the existing power structures begin to fall apart. Once all of the ‘local laws’ of power begin to fail, we must return to general principles, and it is hegemony that gives us a suitable method to understand the mechanics of power in their broadest dimensions

But what in fact even is power? Simply put, power is the capacity to influence. From this perspective, politics is *the operation of power and nothing else*. Politics is above all a practical business of the construction, transformation, and contestation of systems of power. Arguably, there can be no such thing as a theory of power in itself. This is because power is never merely concerned with itself, because power is that thing which is manipulatively involved in the relations, dynamics, and configurations of other things. Everything is *not* political, at least not a priori. Yet anything *can be* political should politics become concerned with its arrangement, whether as a matter of policy or through less intentional or explicit effects. Power, the sole concern of politics, must of necessity itself always be found within another substance. Power is that hungry thing that consumes all and is at once everywhere and nowhere.

It is this liquid, mercurial entity that hegemony best describes. Yet because power in itself must always be present in some other kind of substance, this raises for us the brute fact that we are writing today almost one hundred years since Gramsci’s key prison writings. Our world is very different to that of the 1920s and ’30s. The very existence of neoliberalism, a reactionary movement to route

around all the efforts to restrain capital that were developed in the early twentieth century, attests to this, let alone the emergence of digital technology platforms, global finance, or disaggregated supply chains. For these reasons we need to update and upgrade Gramsci's account (and those of his most notable successors). This book therefore presents a number of developments on the modern and postmodern theories of hegemony.

This book is arranged in three main sections. We encourage our readers to tackle them in any order but would draw attention to the fact that most of the social history is concentrated in part I, the political theory in part II, and the political strategy in part III. We have also included a glossary of key terms for reference.

Power in the Twenty-First Century

Power can only be effectively measured with reference to processes of change and stasis. The way to determine who has the majority of power and who does not is to examine what the dynamics of relative change and stasis are, and to consider which interests are being served in the process, and which intentions are being realised. Given this, which of the competing social, political, economic and cultural agendas of the last great period of global political upheaval, the 1970s and '80s, have acquired the most force and social authority? Of all of the competing social groups to emerge during this period – from the New Right to the New Left – who actually got the world that they wanted? There is a clear answer to this question: the people who got the world that they wanted were the tech entrepreneurs of Silicon Valley and those sections of finance capital closely aligned with them. The precise combination of social liberalisation, anti-egalitarianism, globalisation, deregulation of markets, financialisation of assets and digitisation of media and information that has characterised the leading tendencies of global culture (and we do mean global) can be seen as more or less direct expressions of the interests and values of this particular coalition of class fractions.

It is the success of these forces in establishing a leading position in global society that is the key reason for a widely-remarked-upon sense of cultural stasis in those regions where they are most prevalent and from which they exercise power. This is ultimately symptomatic of an era during which there was no significant political challenge to the social leadership exercised by this grouping of interests, which fully established itself during the administrations of Bill Clinton and Tony Blair in the 1990s. The 'long 1990s', as we set out, is a cultural, political, and economic phenomenon which describes a situation, running up until 2016, where despite intensive technological innovation, social and political relations remained remarkably stable (while still following a distinct trajectory). This is

one way we can understand hegemony. Contrary to mystificatory and obfuscatory accounts of ‘hegemony’ in much of the existing literature, what ‘hegemony’ means is precisely the capacity to organise social change to the advantage of particular social groups, as exhibited by the elite class fractions.

What are the precise mechanisms by which the power of these hegemonic class fractions has been established and maintained? One way to understand the hegemony of neoliberalism is by asserting the empirical specificity of ‘actual existing neoliberalism’: a configuration of ideological narratives, governmental techniques, technological adaptations and organisational procedures. These ought to be distinguished from any simple application of classical neoliberal *theory*, which characteristically tends to conceal its real operations.

There are three key aspects of actually existing neoliberalism as we understand it. First, there is the didactic and symbolic elements of neoliberal ideology, which can easily be discerned within much of contemporary culture: a set of entrepreneurial, competitive, individualist norms that are explicitly encouraged across a range of social sites, from schools to reality television shows and internet influencer culture. Second, there are the infrastructural, technological, and organisational aspects of this process, which are the ways in which neoliberal assumptions are institutionalised by practices of government and even by the specific deployment of new technologies. These elements must be understood as just as significant as the symbolic ones. Third, neoliberalism in practice has always been enabled and supported by authoritarian, racist, and outright antidemocratic practices of government that, despite the libertarian rhetoric, in no way run contrary to its persistent immanent logics.

Hegemony Now

How does this analysis of our political conjuncture require us to change the way we think about hegemonic power? How is it that particular political projects, such as neoliberalism, have been able to establish and maintain positions of hegemony? We have devised three major conceptual developments necessary to properly answer this question: a theory of passive consent, an analysis of material political interests, and a model of platforms and infrastructures. Each of these pushes the basic framework offered by Gramsci and his successors in new directions.

Different publics have participated in hegemonic relations in many distinct ways. ‘Consent’ to hegemonic rule by non-hegemonic groups is complex and takes many differing forms in practice. It becomes clear by analysing the history of political consent that the crude assumption that ‘hegemony’

can only be achieved through majority active consent to particular sets of governing norms is simply untrue.

Hegemony is best understood as a form of leadership where particular groups acquire the ability to determine the general direction of travel of a given social formation, while other groups must only be fully recruited to the views and outlooks of the hegemonic when it is strategically necessary. A good example of the latter situation is the recruitment of senior institutional managers to explicitly or implicitly neoliberal perspectives, even in situations wherein almost all other functionaries of those institutions explicitly reject such perspectives. In such a situation, the prevalence of a complex, multifaceted 'structure of feeling' is what helps to secure general participation in a specific hegemonic project, rather than simple active support for that project on the part of all concerned. 'Structure of feeling' is a term that we derive from the work of Raymond Williams, and refers to the idea that in any given society, at any historical moment, certain social groups will share particular sentiments, world-views and default responses to situations. For Williams, and for us, structures of feeling are always characterised by particular orientations towards hegemonic norms and interests, whether their orientation be one of general acceptance, enthusiastic endorsement, outright opposition or a complex combination of all three. For example, as we will argue in more detail later, for much of the past few decades, probably the most widespread structure of feeling in which citizens of the US or the UK have participated has been one that neither fully embraces nor fully rejects the individualistic, money-driven norms of a society ruled by corporate interests. This prevalent structure of feeling has combined a cynical resignation at the lack of political agency enjoyed by most citizens with a conscious but ineffectual critique of capitalist selfishness and an embrace of the everyday pleasures of an advanced consumer society. This exemplifies the ways in which the great continuum of possible reactions to hegemonic power that lie somewhere between active consent and active dissent can all be understood as varieties of passive consent. Contemporary forms of hegemony often focus on cultivating just this range of responses.

In recent years, the social agents who have established such a system of hegemony are the class fractions of Wall Street and Silicon Valley. We can best consider them primarily as confluences of objective material interests. Contemporary radical theory desperately needs a coherent model of politics as primarily a contest between interests, in order to escape from the debilitating limitations of theoretical models which assume that 'identities' or 'values' are the real objects and subjects of contemporary political struggle. While the post-Marxist impulse to move away from class reductionism was a necessary and correct response to the growing complexity of modern and postmodern societies, the consequent abandonment of any understanding of politics as centrally

concerned with the expression of material interests has been analytically and strategically disastrous. To put it simply: it is true that not all interests can be understood simply or primarily as class interests, but it is also true that what holds together political collectives – such as feminist movements, anti-racist protest groups or movements for transgender rights – is not primarily a shared ‘identity’ so much as a common set of material interests (which may or may not be signified in terms of a shared symbolic identity). Simultaneously, the prioritisation of social ‘values’ or ‘recognition’ as primary political processes always risks complicity with a liberal and idealist conception of politics. Instead, hegemony must always be understood as a crystallisation and ongoing expression of particular social interests.

In order to fully understand the role of passive consent and material interests we must look towards a third dimension of modern hegemonic power: platforms, the structural mode of hegemony. Here we can observe the key technical mechanisms by which the alliance of finance capital and big tech have established their hegemony within contemporary global politics. We consider the political means by which finance capital – greatly assisted by emergent digital technologies – re-established pre-eminence within the capitalist class and across wider society in the 1980s and ’90s: a position that it had lost after the Great Crash of 1929. Alongside that, we can identify the methods that digital technology corporations such as Apple, Facebook and Google used to establish virtual monopolies both on the distribution of information and on key infrastructures of everyday life, communication, and entertainment. It is the platform that is today a key mechanism of infrastructural power, and it is through their control of finance and technology platforms that these groups have come to predominate. Platforms can be understood as instantiations of hegemonic social relations, enabling a range of forms of participation, while always setting subtle limits to the freedom of action enjoyed by their participants.

The Future War of Position

Given our present situation of crisis, what can be done, and by whom? In order to answer that, we need a detailed account of the social composition of the contemporary political moment. Who are the key social and cultural constituencies, who can be regarded as significant collective political actors, and what are the most significant emergent and residual tendencies defining the general directions of travel?

The implications of such an analysis establish the context in which strategies can be constructed for progressive politics in the near future. This concerns questions such as what specific class

alliances and other types of social coalitions might plausibly have the potential to cohere and challenge both the hegemony of the techno-financial elite and the emerging power of the nationalist authoritarian alternative; what type of substantial programme might such coalitions coalesce around; and what types of technical and institutional infrastructures would they need to build in order to realise their political potential?

There is a necessarily socialist character to our strategy, which has both populist and democratic dimensions. Populist, because it must articulate the interests of the people, within the maximal possible political horizon. Democratic, because it must take a basic defence of liberal institutions of democracy and go further, to build new practices of democracy throughout society. Only a left political strategy that can productively combine populist and democratic aspects might have the capacity to supplant the hegemony of technology and finance sectors, and present a credible bulwark against the nationalist authoritarians rising to take their place.